

It is an interesting question, at what point the Aramaic text ended, and the Hebrew text began, in the composite narrative. It is, of course, certain that the Chronicler himself wrote all of this portion of his history in Hebrew (or what may be allowed to pass for Hebrew); and it is hardly less certain that the interpolator was as well acquainted with the one language as with the other. No one will question that the verses 4:43-46, at least, were written in Aramaic;¹³ and it may also be taken for granted that the passage 5:1-6 was allowed to stand in its original Hebrew. But in regard to the intermediate portion, 4:47-63, there is room for doubt, since it is conceivable that the interpolator should have written vss. 57-61 in Aramaic, and then have translated the Chronicler's Hebrew up to and just beyond that point, in order to conceal from sight the real place of the juncture. It is improbable, however, that he would have made himself this unnecessary labor. So far as we can judge, from the very few Jewish productions of this period that have survived, the combination of Hebrew and Aramaic in the same document was a common thing. It was possible, for instance, for the Chronicler to compose Ezra 6:16-18 in Aramaic, and then continue the same narrative in Hebrew in vss. 19 ff.—although he could not have had any reason for wishing to deceive his readers as to where the preceding document ended. Similarly, in Dan. 2:4 we see the change from the one language to the other taking place in the middle of a sentence, the narrative then going on as though nothing had happened. Obviously, such abrupt changes as these were not felt to be disturbing. So far as the Greek of this part of First Esdras is concerned, the last sure sign of an Aramaic original is the *τότε* of vs. 47. Beyond this point, the language seems to me everywhere to suggest Hebrew rather than Aramaic, though I have not been able to find any decisive proof. I therefore believe that the interpolator's Aramaic continued as far as the first words of the Chronicler's narrative, and that everything after this was Hebrew, including vss. 57-61. That is, vs. 47 began

¹³ Aside from the strong probability that this added patch would be written in the same language as the preceding narrative, we have the evidence of *τότε* in vs. 43, the position of the infinitive *ἐκπέμψαι* in vs. 44, and the *κύριε βασιλεῦ* (apparently מַלְכָּא מְרַיָּא, as in Dan. 4:21) in vs. 46. The last-named verse, by the way, contains an evident mistranslation, the conjunction וְ being rendered by *καί*, instead of by some word meaning, "since," "inasmuch as." The Aramaic was: וְדָא הִיא רְבוּתָא (ד) מִן לְוְתָּהּ, "since such munificence is thine." The Aramaic *רְבוּתָא* used here exactly like גְּדוּלָּה in II Sam. 7:21, I Chron. 17:19, where also the Greek rendered by *μεγας ἰσχύος*.